How Many Degrees are We from Fahrenheit 451?

(A Collection on Censorship)

By Amy Ludwig Vanderwater, Mandie Hines, Belissa Escobedo, Zariya Allen and Rhiannon McGavin, and Ellen Hopkins

Are You There, God? By Amy Ludwig Vanderwater

Are You There, God? It's me, Margaret.
I'm sitting with Strega Nona
and this little penguin, Tango.
We got kicked out of the library.
Grownups were yelling, pushing.
Now we're here outside.
Now we're cold.
Harry Potter shared his lunch
and James gave us each a bite
of his giant peach for dessert.
(They got kicked out too.)
Let's just say that
everybody out here
is a little confused.
Would you please ask the bullies
to let us back in?
If they don't like our ideas
they can leave us on our shelves.
But we'd like to be open books
For the open minds
Who take us in their hands
Smiling and nodding
smiling and needing.
We'd like to be open books
for the open minds
who read.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Amy Ludwig Vanderwater
Book: On-Line
ISBN: N/A
Publisher: Poemfarm.amylv.com
Date (Month/Year): October 1, 2012
Web Location:
http://www.poemfarm.amylv.com/2012/10/are-you-there-god-banned-books-week.html

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INTRODUCTION

Book banning is the most widespread form of censorship in the United States, with children's literature being the primary target.

But to pull books from a school library is a recipe for disaster. Why? Because it supports a false idea that there is one version of life that is acceptable. The reality is . . . We are a varied society, with wildly diverse backgrounds, values, and experiences. And banning books ***won't*** *make the concepts or societal issues go away.*

The heat is on, but how many degrees of separation are we from Ray Bradbury's Fahrenheit 451 -- where technology rules society, intellectualism is curbed, books are ***illegal*** *and professional "firemen" burn any books they find?*

How Many Degrees are We from Fahrenheit 451? A Collection on Censorship by Mandie Hines, Ellen Hopkins Amy Ludwig Vanderwater, Belissa Escobedo, Zariya Allen and Rhiannon McGavin

The Subtlety of Censorship by Mandie Hines

The subtlety of censorship . . .
It creeps in like
fog at dusk
under the guise
of protection.

These words,
these themes,
these ideas
are not suitable
for children.

We think
maybe that's
right.
Maybe they are
too young.

Perhaps individual
discretion is too
much work.

But in the inky
blackness of night
the murky clouds conceal.

The broad strokes of
censorship are seized
to oppress the minority,

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grind down the powerless, and
silence the truth.

In the starkness of day,
everything has been
sanitized
and as the horror sinks in,
we walk around with duct-taped
mouths and fear in
our eyes.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Mandie Hines
Book: On-Line
ISBN: N/A
Publisher: Mandiehines.com
Date (Month/Year): May 17, 2019
Web Location:
https://www.mandiehines.com/2019/05/17/poem-subtlety-of-censorship/

Somewhere in America (excerpt)
by Belissa Escobedo, Zariya Allen and Rhiannon McGavin

(You see,) Here in America, in every single state, they have
a set of standards for every subject

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A collection of lessons that the teacher's required to teach
by the end of the term
But the greatest lessons you'll ever teach us will not come
from your syllabus
The greatest lessons you will ever teach us, you will not
even remember

You never told us what we weren't allowed to say
We just learned how to hold our tongues
Now somewhere in America, there is a child holding a copy
of "Catcher in the Rye" and there is a child holding a gun
But only one of these things have been banned by their
state government
And it's not the one that can rip through flesh
It's the one that says "*F* you" on more pages than one

Because we must control what the people say, and how
they think
And if they want to become the overseer of their own
selves, then we'll show them a real one

And somewhere in America, there's a child sitting at his

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mother's computer, reading the homepage of the KKK's website, and that's open to the public
But that child will never have read "To Kill a Mockingbird" because the school has banned it for its use of the "N" word

Maya Angelou is prohibited because we're not allowed to talk about rape in school
We were taught that 'just because something happens, doesn't mean you are to talk about it'
[Shhhhhhh!]

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Belissa Escobedo, Zariya Allen and Rhiannon McGavin
Book: On-Line
ISBN: N/A
Publisher: Effervenscence.wordpress.com
Date (Month/Year): 2016
Web Location:
https://effervescene.wordpress.com/2016/04/15/somewhere-in-america-by-belissa-escobedo-rhiannon-mcgavin-and-zariya-allen/

Find out more about the authors on their website at https://www.poetpuffgirls.com/

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Manifesto by Ellen Hopkins

[So . . . .] To you zealots and bigots and false
patriots who live in fear of discourse.
You screamers and banners and burners
who would force books
off shelves in your brand name
of greater good.

You say you're afraid for children,
innocents ripe for corruption
by perversion or sorcery on the page.
But sticks and stones do break
bones, and ignorance is no armor.
You do not speak for me,
and will not deny my kids magic
in favor of miracles.
You say you're afraid for America,
the red, white and blue corroded
by terrorists, socialists, the sexually
confused. But we are a vast quilt
of patchwork cultures and multi-gendered
identities. You cannot speak for those

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whose ancestors braved

different seas.

You say you're afraid for God,

the living word eroded by Muhammed

and Darwin and Magdalene.

But the omnipotent sculptor of heaven

and earth designed intelligence.

Surely you dare not speak

for the father, who opens

his arms to all.

A word to the unwise.

Torch every book.

Char every page.

Burn every word to ash.

Ideas are incombustible.

And therein lies your real fear.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ellen Hopkins
Book: On-Line
ISBN: N/A
Publisher: Simon and Schuster Publishing.com
Date (Month/Year):
Web Location:
http://simonandschusterpublishing.com/banned-books-week/assets/manifesto-2011.pdf

CLOSING

In the words of Stephen Chbosky, author of the often banned The Perks of Being a Wallflower: "Banning books gives us silence when we need speech. It closes our ears when we need to listen. It makes us blind when we need sight."

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